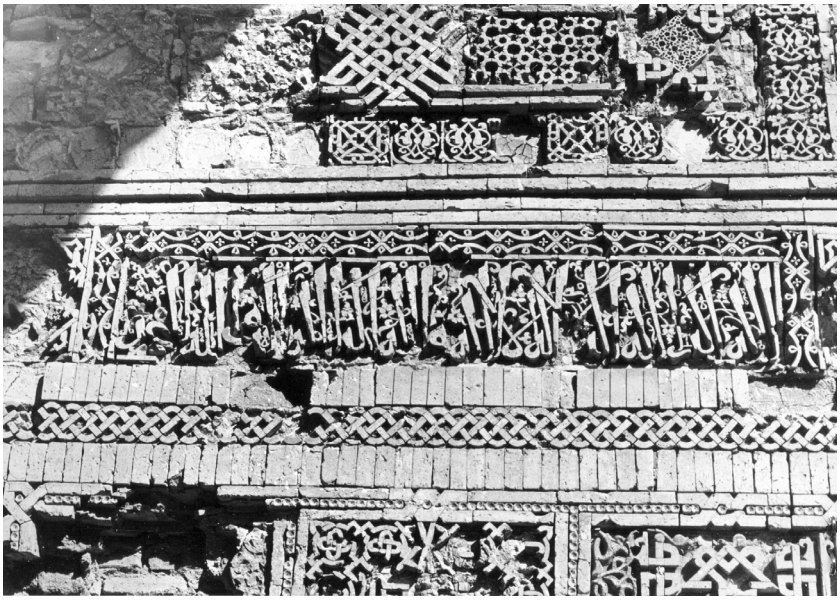


Figure 4.7 *Shah-i Mashhad* madrasa*, southern monumental entrance, interior with inscription. © Photograph Bernt Glatzer* c. *1970.*

naskh inscription of a Hadith apparently of Shi'i association (Figure 4.9).[47] The presence of verses from Surat al-Fath is unusual in the eastern Islamic lands,[48] and Najimi's new readings and reinterpretations make all the more poignant the lingering questions about the *madrasa*'s sectarian affiliation(s), the patron's role in the complex's conception, as well as the intended audience(s) of the inscriptions. The import of juxtaposing all of these inscriptions in an admittedly complicated epigraphic program is discussed below.

But first, it should be noted that many factors rendered difficult both reading and also fully comprehending epigraphic programs, not only at Shah-i Mashhad but also at the other architectural sites attributed to this first phase of elite patronage within the territories of the Firuzkuh Shansabanis (cf. Volume II for late twelfth-century architectural patronage). Even though Shansabani-patronized inscriptional programs were almost exclusively in Arabic,[49] their varying and ornate scripts often hindered rather than facilitated reading. Furthermore, the inscriptions varied greatly in content, ranging from Qur'anic verses, historical and funerary inscriptions, Hadith, and possibly even didactic texts – the last exemplified in Shah-i Mashhad's *takbir* of *tashriq*. All of these challenges were probably as pronounced or perhaps even more so when the buildings' programs were complete. Thus, all considerations of the overall design, composition, and readership of the inscriptions on monuments throughout the Firuzkuh Shansabanis' realms must necessarily proceed from the premise that readers of the inscriptions were extremely few.[50]